zones classified as ‘highly active’ along our long and unsettled border, should get an allowance that would be higher than that of a field area or counter-insurgency area allowance. In this case we called the joint secretaries from the ministry of defence, defence (finance), and finance to the MO operations room and after showing them these zones on the map, gave them the rationale, logic and the financial implications related to the proposal. In just one meeting, it was agreed to in principle by everyone. We moved the file after that, and got the government’s approval in a month or two. Over 90 per cent of the beneficiaries of this allowance, which is in force even today, happen to be from the infantry.

On 29 October 1999, a massive and unforgettable natural disaster struck in the coastal districts of Orissa near Cuttack. The supercyclone, called Paradip, a deadly mix of a hurricane and a gigantic tidal surge, left about 10,000 dead, and over a million homeless. The massive surge travelled upto 10–15 kilometres inland, destroying everything in its wake. It was one of the biggest cyclones to have hit India. The state government sought help from the ministry of defence and the armed forces were requisitioned. All communications with the region had been cut off. Army columns were rushed in by road from Ranchi to the disaster-hit areas. Air force and army helicopters as well as naval ships were pressed into rescue and relief operations. The defence minister, George Fernandes, asked me to accompany him to Orissa as he wished to oversee the aid being rendered by the armed forces. We could not land in the state capital as the air traffic facilities and communications at Bhubaneswar airport had been disabled, and therefore had to land at Ranchi, and then proceed ahead by helicopter.

We were horrified to see the devastation caused by this twister. Like a giant vacuum cleaner it had wiped out many villages without any trace. The only shreds of evidence that remained were small clean patches where people’s homes were once! The army columns moving by vehicles faced a herculean task of clearing hundreds of